



The Question That Wouldn't Go Away

There are moments in every career that only make sense in hindsight.

One of mine began more than a decade ago in Botswana.

At the time, I was involved in helping the Botswana Meat Commission rethink its future. Like many state-owned enterprises across Africa, the organisation faced a changing competitive landscape. International markets were evolving, customer expectations were shifting, and the business could no longer rely on the assumptions that had shaped its success for decades. The challenge before us was not simply to improve operational performance. It was to imagine an entirely different future and to develop a strategy capable of taking the organisation there.

Like many strategists, I immersed myself in market analysis, competitive positioning, value chains and organisational capabilities. We debated growth opportunities, evaluated new market possibilities and explored how the organisation might reposition itself within an increasingly global industry. The strategic logic gradually became clearer, and with it came a growing confidence that we had identified a viable direction for the future.





Yet as the work progressed, I found myself becoming increasingly uneasy.

The strategy made sense.

The organisation did not.

I remember sitting in executive discussions watching intelligent, committed leaders respond to exactly the same strategic conversation in remarkably different ways. Some immediately recognised the opportunities that lay ahead. Others acknowledged the logic of the strategy while remaining quietly sceptical that the organisation could ever make the transition. A few participated enthusiastically in workshops yet continued making decisions that reflected yesterday's assumptions rather than tomorrow's ambitions.

What struck me was that everyone possessed essentially the same information. They had attended the same workshops, reviewed the same analyses and understood the same commercial realities. Yet they appeared to be inhabiting different organisations.

At the time, I assumed this was simply one of the frustrations of strategic change. Every organisation, I believed, contained innovators, pragmatists and sceptics. That was simply the nature of leadership.

Only much later did I realise that I had witnessed something far more important.

The strategy itself was never the problem.

The problem lay in how different executives interpreted the strategy before deciding how they would respond to it.

I did not yet have the language to describe what I was observing, but the question stayed with me. Why do capable executives, working within the same organisation and pursuing the same strategic objectives, arrive at such different levels of commitment?

For several years, the question remained unanswered.

Instead, another consulting engagement gradually deepened the puzzle.

This time the assignment was not to develop strategy but to align an organisation around one that already existed. Rather than beginning with markets and competitive positioning, the work focused on organisational architecture. We reviewed governance arrangements, executive structures, spans of control, talent requirements, remuneration philosophy and implementation planning, seeking to ensure that every element of the organisation reinforced the strategic direction rather than working against it. The methodology reflected the prevailing wisdom of organisation design: establish a



compelling case for change, align executive responsibilities with strategic priorities, integrate governance and talent systems, and create a transition plan capable of sustaining implementation.

It was a disciplined and comprehensive process, built upon a principle that has shaped organisation design for decades. As Henry Mintzberg famously observed, structure follows strategy. Once the strategic destination becomes clear, the organisation should be redesigned to support the journey.

I believed that completely.

In many respects, I still do.

Strategy without organisational alignment is little more than aspiration. Reporting relationships matter. Governance matters. Executive roles matter. Incentives matter. Organisations that fail to align these elements rarely execute strategy consistently.

But once again, something refused to fit.

Even where organisational alignment improved significantly, executive commitment remained uneven.

Some leaders flourished under the new arrangements. Others complied without conviction. Still others quietly continued operating according to the logic of the previous organisation.

Nothing in the organisational chart explained the difference.

The reporting lines were identical.

The governance framework was shared.

The performance expectations were clear.

Yet the organisation continued to experience multiple realities simultaneously.

Looking back now, I realise that both engagements—the strategy work in Botswana and the later organisation design project—were confronting me with the same underlying phenomenon.

I simply wasn't looking in the right place.

I was searching for the answer in strategy.

Then I searched for it in organisational design.

Eventually I would discover that it existed somewhere else entirely—not in the formal architecture of the organisation, but in the invisible architecture of executive judgement.



It would take another decade of consulting, followed by doctoral research into strategic transformation, before those experiences finally converged into a coherent explanation.

And when they did, they fundamentally changed the way I think about organisational alignment.

When Alignment Became the Answer

If my experience in Botswana had taught me that strategy alone was insufficient, my next major engagement convinced me that neither was organisational design.

The assignment was fundamentally different. This time, the strategic direction had already been established. My role was to help redesign the organisation so that its structure, governance, leadership responsibilities and people systems would support the successful execution of that strategy. It was a comprehensive exercise in organisational alignment—one that reflected many of the established principles of organisation design and strategic management.

The underlying logic was difficult to dispute.

Organisations execute strategy through people, and people work within systems. If those systems are poorly designed, even the most compelling strategy will struggle to gain traction. Executive roles become blurred. Decision rights overlap. Accountability becomes fragmented. Incentives reward behaviours that no longer serve the organisation's future. Gradually, the organisation begins pulling in different directions.

The solution appeared straightforward. Create greater alignment between strategy and organisational architecture.

Our work therefore extended well beyond organisational charts. We examined governance structures, executive accountabilities, reporting relationships, remuneration frameworks, talent management processes and implementation plans. Each element was considered not in isolation, but as part of an integrated system designed to reinforce the organisation's strategic objectives.

It was rigorous work, informed by decades of thinking in organisation design. The methodology recognised that organisational performance depends upon the coherence of multiple reinforcing systems rather than the optimisation of any single component. Structure should support strategy. Governance should enable effective decision-making. Performance management should encourage the behaviours the future demands. Leadership capability should be developed intentionally rather than left to chance. When these elements reinforce one another, organisations become capable of executing strategy with consistency and discipline.

At the time, I believed this represented the missing piece I had been searching for.



If organisations could align their structures with their strategic intent, surely the uneven execution I had witnessed in Botswana would begin to disappear.

Yet something unexpected happened.

Despite the quality of the organisational design, executives continued to respond to the same strategic environment in remarkably different ways.

Some embraced the redesigned organisation almost immediately. They saw new opportunities for collaboration, recognised the rationale behind revised governance arrangements and actively sought to shape the organisation's future. Others accepted the changes professionally but remained emotionally detached, complying with the new structures without ever truly committing to them. Still others viewed exactly the same organisational changes with suspicion, interpreting them as a loss of influence, increased bureaucracy or uncertainty about their future role.

The organisation had become more aligned.

Its executives had not.

That distinction became increasingly difficult to ignore.

Initially, I searched for familiar explanations. Perhaps it was simply a question of personality. Some leaders naturally embrace uncertainty while others prefer stability. Perhaps the differences reflected variations in competence, experience or leadership maturity. Organisational politics also seemed a plausible explanation. Every organisation contains competing interests, informal alliances and historical tensions that shape how change is received.

Each explanation captured part of the picture.

None of them explained it completely.

The more organisations I worked with, the more I noticed that executives occupying similar positions, with comparable experience and operating under identical governance arrangements, often interpreted the same strategic initiative in profoundly different ways. They were not disagreeing about the facts. They were disagreeing about what those facts meant.

That realisation changed the way I began thinking about strategic alignment.

Until then, I had largely understood alignment as a structural challenge. The task of leadership was to ensure that strategy, structure, governance, incentives and talent formed a coherent system capable of delivering organisational objectives. I still believe that to be true. Poor organisational design remains one of the most common reasons strategies fail.



But I had begun to suspect that structural alignment was addressing only part of the problem.

Organisation design creates the conditions for coordinated action.

It does not guarantee shared interpretation.

Somewhere between the strategic plan and executive behaviour, leaders were making sense of what the organisation was asking of them. They were judging whether the proposed direction was legitimate, whether it deserved their commitment and whether they believed they possessed the capacity to influence its success. Those judgements were invisible to organisational charts, yet they appeared to shape behaviour long before that behaviour became visible to everyone else.

At the time, I regarded this simply as an interesting observation. I had no framework for explaining it, and certainly no ambition to develop one.

That changed during a later engagement with one of the Gulf region's oldest family-owned business groups.

It was there, while examining the dynamics of board governance and executive decision-making, that I began to realise the most important conversations in an organisation often occur in the spaces that organisational charts cannot capture—the white space between reporting lines.

The White Space Between Reporting Lines

The next piece of the puzzle emerged in a place I least expected.

Having spent years helping organisations formulate strategy and redesign organisational structures, I found myself working with one of the Gulf region's oldest family-owned conglomerates. On the surface, the assignment was about corporate governance. Like many successful family businesses transitioning from entrepreneurial leadership to institutional stewardship, the organisation sought to strengthen the relationship between its board, executive management and operating companies while preserving the values that had underpinned its success for generations.

It was, once again, a question of alignment.

But this time the challenge felt different.

Unlike many publicly listed corporations, family businesses are not held together solely by formal structures. They are also bound by history, relationships, identity and deeply shared assumptions about what the organisation exists to accomplish. The boardroom is therefore more than a place where strategic decisions are approved. It is where the organisation continually negotiates its identity and renews its understanding of what constitutes legitimate action.



As I observed board deliberations and executive interactions, I became increasingly aware that the formal governance framework explained only part of what was happening. The board certainly exercised authority through policies, delegated powers and strategic oversight. Yet its greatest influence appeared to lie elsewhere.

It shaped how executives understood the organisation itself.

Two executives could leave the same board meeting having heard the same discussion, reviewed the same financial information and received exactly the same strategic direction, yet they often departed with strikingly different understandings of what the board had actually asked of them. One interpreted the discussion as an invitation to innovate. Another heard a call for greater operational discipline. A third concluded that caution was the safest course of action until the board's intentions became clearer.

The governance process had been identical.

The interpretations were not.

I began to realise that the most important work of governance was occurring in places that organisational charts could never reveal. It was taking place in the invisible space between institutional expectations and executive interpretation—in what I came to think of as the white space between reporting lines.

That phrase has remained with me ever since because it captures something that conventional organisation design rarely addresses.

Reporting lines establish authority.

Governance allocates accountability.

Decision rights clarify who may decide.

Performance systems specify what should be achieved.

Yet none of these mechanisms determines how individual executives interpret the meaning of those expectations before deciding how they will act.

This insight fundamentally altered my understanding of governance.

For many years, governance literature has understandably concentrated on structures. We debate board composition, committee effectiveness, independence, fiduciary responsibilities, accountability frameworks and oversight mechanisms. These remain critically important. Without



robust governance, organisations become vulnerable to inconsistency, poor decision-making and strategic drift.

But governance is also an interpretive institution.

Its influence extends beyond the decisions it formally makes to the meanings executives derive from those decisions. Every board communicates more than resolutions and policies. It communicates what the organisation values, what it considers legitimate, whose voices matter, how risk should be understood and what kind of future deserves commitment. Those messages are not simply received; they are interpreted.

The implications of that realisation began to reshape the way I understood strategic transformation.

Perhaps organisations do not fail because executives reject strategy.

Perhaps they fail because executives construct different realities from the same strategy.

The distinction is subtle, but profound.

If leaders are responding to different interpretations of the organisation's future, then no amount of structural alignment will produce genuinely coordinated action. The organisation may appear aligned on paper while remaining deeply fragmented beneath the surface. Executive meetings become characterised by apparent agreement but divergent implementation. Governance frameworks become increasingly sophisticated, yet behavioural consistency remains elusive. Strategy is endorsed collectively but enacted individually.

For the first time, the experiences from Botswana, the organisation design engagement and the family business assignment began to converge into a single line of inquiry.

The challenge was no longer understanding how organisations align their structures.

It was understanding how executives align their judgement.

That question eventually became the foundation of my doctoral research. Rather than beginning with organisational systems, I began with the executives themselves, asking why individuals operating within the same institutional context frequently embark on remarkably different trajectories of engagement during strategic transformation. What emerged was not simply another explanation of change resistance or leadership behaviour. It revealed a deeper evaluative process through which executives determine whether organisational change is worthy of their commitment before they decide how they will act.



It was this shift—from structure to judgement—that ultimately led to the development of the Worldview Levels of Activation, a framework that sought to explain the invisible mechanisms connecting institutional change with executive action.

From Alignment to Judgement

My doctoral research did not begin with the intention of developing a new theoretical framework. In many respects, it began with a question that had been quietly following me throughout my consulting career. Whether I was developing corporate strategy, redesigning organisations or working with boards to strengthen governance, I kept encountering the same phenomenon. Executives operating within the same organisation, exposed to the same strategy and working under the same governance arrangements, consistently demonstrated remarkably different levels of commitment to organisational change. The conventional explanations—personality, organisational politics, communication failures or resistance to change—each offered part of the answer, but none seemed capable of explaining the consistency of the pattern.

The more I reflected on these experiences, the more convinced I became that the critical moment in strategic transformation occurred long before behaviour became visible. Before executives committed themselves to a new strategic direction, they first had to make sense of what that direction meant. They were not simply responding to organisational change; they were interpreting it. In doing so, they were making a series of deeply evaluative judgements about whether the proposed future deserved their commitment and whether they saw themselves as capable of contributing to its success.

This shifted the focus of my research in an important way. Rather than asking why organisations experience resistance during change, I began asking how executives interpret institutional expectations before deciding how they will respond. That distinction may appear subtle, but it fundamentally changes where we look for the mechanisms that explain strategic transformation. Instead of searching for answers in organisational structures or leadership behaviours alone, attention shifts to the cognitive and evaluative processes through which executives construct meaning from the institutional environments in which they operate.

As the research progressed, a remarkably consistent pattern began to emerge. Executives appeared to move through three interconnected evaluations before their intentions translated into action. The first concerned legitimacy. Leaders assessed whether the proposed strategic direction was credible, appropriate and consistent with their understanding of the organisation's purpose. Change that lacked legitimacy rarely generated meaningful engagement, regardless of how well it was communicated or how compelling the business case appeared.



Where legitimacy was established, executives then evaluated their relational obligation. This was not simply a contractual obligation arising from their organisational role, but a deeper judgement concerning the responsibilities they believed they owed to colleagues, stakeholders and the institution itself. Some experienced transformation as an opportunity to fulfil their stewardship of the organisation's future, while others regarded it as another management initiative demanding compliance but little personal commitment.

Finally, executives evaluated their own agency. They asked themselves whether they possessed the authority, capability and influence necessary to make a meaningful contribution to the transformation. Even highly committed leaders often disengaged when they concluded that their actions were unlikely to influence organisational outcomes. Conversely, executives who believed they could make a difference frequently became powerful advocates for change, even under difficult organisational conditions.

What became increasingly clear was that these evaluations did not occur independently. They formed an interconnected system in which each judgement influenced the others. Perceiving a strategic initiative as legitimate often strengthened a sense of obligation towards its success, while a strong sense of obligation frequently reinforced an executive's willingness to exercise agency. Likewise, diminished perceptions of agency could gradually erode commitment, even when the strategic direction itself remained compelling. Executive engagement, therefore, was not the product of isolated attitudes or personality traits, but of an ongoing evaluative process through which institutional expectations were translated into voluntary action.

Looking back, I realised that I had been observing this process throughout my consulting career without recognising it for what it was. The strategy work in Botswana first exposed the uneven ways in which executives responded to a shared strategic vision. Organisation design demonstrated that structural alignment, while essential, could not by itself produce shared commitment. The family business engagement revealed that boards shape executive behaviour not only through governance mechanisms but also by influencing how organisational purpose and legitimacy are interpreted. My doctoral research did not replace these earlier experiences; it connected them, providing a coherent explanation for a pattern that had been visible all along.

This also changed the way I think about organisational alignment. For decades, the discipline has quite rightly concentrated on aligning strategy, structure, governance, talent and incentives. These remain indispensable components of effective execution. Yet they represent only the visible architecture of organisational life. Beneath that architecture lies an interpretive layer through which executives decide whether institutional expectations deserve their commitment and whether they believe they can meaningfully contribute to their realisation. Until that deeper layer



is understood, organisations may achieve impressive structural coherence while continuing to experience inconsistent executive engagement.

It was this insight that eventually led to the development of what I came to call the Worldview Levels of Activation. Rather than viewing strategic transformation as a direct consequence of organisational interventions, the framework explains how institutional change is filtered through executive judgements concerning legitimacy, relational obligation and agency before it becomes voluntary behaviour. In doing so, it suggests that the missing dimension of organisation design has never been structural. It has been interpretive.

The Missing Dimension of Organisation Design

Every discipline reaches a point where it must confront the limits of its own assumptions.

Organisation design is no exception.

Over the past half-century, the field has made extraordinary contributions to our understanding of strategy execution. It has shown us how structures shape coordination, how governance distributes authority, how incentives reinforce desired behaviours and how talent systems sustain organisational capability. These insights have transformed the way organisations are designed and managed, and few would dispute their importance.

Yet they all share a common assumption. They presume that once organisations establish the appropriate institutional conditions, executives will respond in broadly similar ways. Differences in behaviour are generally attributed to communication failures, resistance to change, inadequate leadership or poor implementation.

My research suggests that the explanation lies somewhere else.

The missing dimension is not another organisational variable to be incorporated into the design process. It is the evaluative process through which executives interpret the organisation before deciding how they will engage with it. In other words, organisations do not simply create structures that people inhabit; they create institutional environments that people continually interpret. Those interpretations, rather than the structures themselves, ultimately shape executive commitment.

This became the foundation of what I came to describe as the Worldview Levels of Activation. Rather than treating executive engagement as an automatic consequence of organisational interventions, the framework explains how institutional change is translated into voluntary action through a sequence of interconnected evaluations. Executives do not move directly from strategic intent to behaviour. They first assess whether the change is legitimate, whether it creates a



meaningful obligation to act and whether they believe they possess sufficient agency to influence its outcome. These evaluations determine whether strategic initiatives remain organisational ambitions or become lived organisational realities.

This perspective also explains something that traditional organisation design has struggled to account for. Why do two organisations implementing remarkably similar transformation programmes often experience completely different outcomes? Why do executives exposed to the same strategic vision display varying levels of enthusiasm, ownership and persistence? Why do some leadership teams develop a shared sense of purpose while others remain fragmented despite apparently strong governance and well-defined structures?

The answer, I believe, is that they are not responding to the same organisation.

They are responding to the organisation as they understand it.

That distinction is far more significant than it first appears. Every executive carries into the boardroom a set of deeply embedded assumptions about authority, responsibility, organisational purpose, leadership and change. These assumptions are not formed during the transformation programme itself. They are shaped over years of professional experience, organisational socialisation and institutional exposure. When a new strategy is introduced, executives do not simply receive it as objective information. They interpret it through these underlying assumptions, constructing a view of what the strategy demands, what risks it creates and what role they should play in its implementation.

Seen from this perspective, strategic transformation becomes less about persuading executives to support change and more about understanding the interpretive lenses through which they are already viewing it.

This does not diminish the importance of strategy or organisation design. On the contrary, it extends them. Strategy continues to define the destination. Organisation design continues to create the institutional conditions necessary for execution. Governance continues to establish accountability and decision rights. These remain indispensable foundations of organisational performance.

However, none of them determines how executives will interpret those institutional conditions.

That interpretive work is undertaken by the executives themselves.

For boards and executive teams, this has profound implications. It suggests that alignment cannot be measured solely by organisational charts, governance frameworks or implementation milestones. These indicate whether the organisation has been designed coherently, but they reveal



very little about whether its leaders have developed a shared understanding of the future they are being asked to create.

An organisation may therefore appear highly aligned while remaining deeply fragmented beneath the surface. Executive meetings may conclude with unanimous agreement, yet participants leave with fundamentally different understandings of what has been decided. Governance processes may function efficiently, while interpretations of organisational purpose quietly diverge. Strategies may be formally endorsed but enacted inconsistently because leaders are pursuing different versions of the same future.

Perhaps the most important lesson from my journey is that organisational alignment is not simply a structural achievement. It is an interpretive accomplishment. It emerges when executives begin to converge not only around common goals, but around a shared understanding of why those goals matter, what they require of them and how their own actions can contribute to their achievement.

Only then does strategy become more than a document.

It becomes a shared way of seeing the future.

A Different Way of Thinking About Strategy Execution

When I look back across the consulting assignments that shaped my career, I no longer see them as isolated engagements. What once appeared to be unrelated projects—a corporate strategy in Botswana, an organisation redesign elsewhere in Africa, governance work within a Gulf family business and, ultimately, doctoral research into strategic transformation—now appear as successive chapters in a much larger story. Each engagement illuminated a different part of the same phenomenon. Strategy explained where organisations wanted to go. Organisation design explained how they intended to get there. Governance clarified who would make the journey possible. Yet none adequately explained why equally capable executives, operating within the same institutional environment, so often embarked upon remarkably different journeys.

The answer, I have come to believe, lies in recognising that strategy execution is as much an interpretive process as it is an organisational one. We have become exceptionally skilled at designing institutions. We know how to create governance frameworks, redesign structures, clarify decision rights and align incentives. These capabilities remain essential because organisations require coherent institutional architecture if they are to execute strategy consistently. However, institutions do not implement strategy. People do. More specifically, executives do. And executives act not only in response to organisational systems, but in response to the meanings they construct from those systems.



This has important implications for how we think about leadership. Senior executives often devote considerable attention to communicating strategy more effectively. Town hall meetings become more frequent. Communication plans become more sophisticated. Presentation decks become more compelling. While these initiatives undoubtedly have value, they frequently assume that the challenge lies in transmitting information more clearly. My experience suggests that the greater challenge often lies elsewhere. Executives are rarely short of information. More often, they differ in how they interpret that information and in the conclusions they draw about what it requires of them.

Seen in this light, the role of leadership begins to change. It is no longer sufficient to ensure that everyone understands the strategy. Leaders must also create the conditions through which executives develop a shared interpretation of its legitimacy, a shared sense of responsibility for its success and a shared confidence that their actions can meaningfully influence its outcome. Alignment, therefore, becomes something richer than structural coherence. It becomes the gradual convergence of executive judgement.

This also changes the role of boards. Traditionally, boards are viewed as custodians of governance, risk and strategic oversight. Those responsibilities remain fundamental, but they represent only part of the board's influence. Every question a board asks, every priority it reinforces and every decision it endorses communicates something about what the organisation values. Boards do not merely allocate resources or approve strategic initiatives; they shape the interpretive environment within which executives make sense of those initiatives. Whether intentionally or not, they influence how legitimacy is constructed, how responsibility is understood and how agency is experienced throughout the executive team.

For organisation designers, this perspective offers an opportunity to extend rather than replace existing practice. The objective is not to abandon the principles that have guided the discipline for decades. Strategy must still be translated into structures. Governance must still clarify accountability. Talent must still be developed deliberately. Incentives must still reinforce desired behaviours. These remain indispensable foundations of organisational effectiveness. However, if we stop there, we risk assuming that structural alignment inevitably produces behavioural alignment. Experience repeatedly suggests that it does not.

The next frontier of organisation design, therefore, may not lie in creating more sophisticated structures, but in understanding more deeply how those structures are interpreted by the people expected to lead them. Designing organisations for execution requires more than aligning reporting relationships and governance mechanisms. It requires leaders to recognise that every organisational



intervention enters an interpretive world already populated by assumptions, beliefs and expectations that shape how executives understand the future before they begin creating it.

That insight has fundamentally changed my own practice. When I enter an organisation today, I still examine its strategy, governance, structures and leadership systems. Those questions remain indispensable. But I now ask another set of questions that I once overlooked. How are executives interpreting the organisation's purpose? Do they share a common understanding of why the proposed future matters? Do they experience genuine responsibility for bringing that future into existence? Do they believe they possess the influence to shape its outcome?

Increasingly, I have found that the answers to these questions reveal more about an organisation's readiness for transformation than its organisational chart ever could.

Perhaps that is the lesson these experiences have been teaching me all along. Strategy does not fail because organisations lack plans. Organisation design does not fail because structures are unimportant. Governance does not fail because boards lack authority. They fall short when we assume that institutional change automatically becomes executive commitment.

It does not.

Between the organisation we design and the organisation that ultimately emerges lies the judgement of the people entrusted with leading it. That judgement is neither incidental nor peripheral to strategic transformation. It is the mechanism through which institutional intentions become organisational reality.

If organisation design has traditionally been concerned with aligning structures, then its future may well lie in aligning something far less visible, but infinitely more consequential: the executive worldviews through which strategy is understood, commitment is formed and transformation ultimately becomes possible.